Parshas Shmini

Growth Within Structure, Reaching Without Burning

Shmini · Sefiras HaOmer · Chesed and Gevurah · Teva and L'malah Min HaTeva

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I. The Timing Is Not Accidental

Parshas Shmini almost always comes immediately after Pesach. Those of us in Eretz Yisrael (the Land of Israel) have already had a bit of time to land after Yom Tov, while those in Chutz LaAretz (outside the Land) move through a much tighter transition, coming straight from the seventh day of Pesach into Shabbos. Either way, we arrive at Shmini still holding onto what just happened.

And that matters. Because this parsha is not describing another moment of revelation. It is describing what comes after. After Yetzias Mitzrayim (the Exodus from Egypt). After Kriyas Yam Suf (the Splitting of the Sea). After a clear giluy (revelation) of HaKadosh Baruch Hu (the Holy One, Blessed be He) acting within the world.

The question now is not what was revealed. The question is whether that can be lived.

II. Seven and Eight

Seven represents teva (nature), the natural cycle, the structure of the world as it runs. We spoke at length erev (the eve of) Shvi'i shel Pesach (the Seventh Day of Passover) about how that sheva (seven) plays out. The isaruta d'letata (awakening from below) — expressed in walking into the yam (sea) — drew the isaruta d'le'eila (awakening from above). And in that moment, even the miraculous was experienced b'toch (within) the world itself.

The goal of that seven was not only to witness the miracle, but to begin drawing what is above nature down into the natural world. But a moment of drawing down is not yet a life of drawing

down. And that is exactly where Shmini (the Eighth) begins — not as a break from what came before, but as its continuation. To take what was revealed and begin living it through avodah (service), where the Shechinah (Divine Presence) rests b'toch (within) the structure itself — not only in moments of revelation, but in the day to day.

Eight, Shmini, is l'malah min hateva (above and beyond nature). Not instead of the world, but beyond its limitations. Not escaping reality, but bringing Elokus (Godliness) into the world in a way that does not naturally belong within it. We, as Jews, are supposed to be living inside of teva, carrying our avodah and our tafkidim (life tasks and roles) day by day. But we are also supposed to be drawing godliness down into that reality. And in order to bring it down, we have to exist a little bit above. Our regular sheva needs to be lived on the level of shmini.

III. The Eighth Day

For seven days, Moshe Rabbeinu (Moses our Teacher) performs the avodah in the Mishkan (Tabernacle). He goes through each step, each detail, showing exactly how it is done. These were not practice runs. Moshe was demonstrating what avodah looks like when it is done within the structure that HaKadosh Baruch Hu set. Every step had a place, every action had a time, every detail mattered.

The mefarshim (commentators) explain that those seven days correspond to the seven days Moshe spent arguing with Hashem at the sneh (burning bush) — his hesitation, his resistance, his back and forth. That time was given back to him here. He got a taste, he got his time. But it was not meant to be permanent. Only after those seven days does the Torah say:

> וַיְהִי בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁמִינִי קָרָא מֹשֶׁה לְאַהֲרֹן וּלְבָנָיו וּלְזִקְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
>
> *"And it was on the eighth day, Moshe called to Aharon and to his sons and to the elders of Israel."*
>
> — Vayikra 9:1

Now it becomes real. The avodah is no longer being shown — it is being lived. And this is not about being the Kohen Gadol (High Priest), or even a Kohen (Priest). It is about living in the awareness that the Mishkan is present, that the Shechinah is here, that we are meant to be drawing it down into the world. As I was trying to explain to my children at the Seudas Mashiach (the meal celebrating the imminent arrival of Moshiach) this year — we are meant to be living as though Moshiach is already here. Shmini is the reminder.

IV. When It Works, It Is a Neis

There is a mashal (analogy) that captures something of what Aharon HaKohen (Aaron the Priest) must have felt in that moment. Anyone who has worked in software development knows the difference between a development environment and going live. In development — a controlled, sterile, theoretical testing space — things work over and over. It is predictable, contained, reliable. But when something goes live, when it works in the real world, in the non-sterile, non-theoretical environment, it feels like a neis (miracle).

That gap — between the theoretical and the real, between the test and the actual — is exactly what Aharon faced. After all the preparation, after watching Moshe for seven days, after all the instruction — and even the genuine fear that perhaps his avodah would not be accepted — Moshe reassured him. And then:

וַתֵּצֵא אֵשׁ מִלִּפְנֵי ה׳ וַתֹּאכַל עַל הַמִּזְבֵּחַ אֶת הָעֹלָה וְאֶת הַחֲלָבִים

"A fire came forth from before Hashem and consumed upon the mizbeach (altar) the offering and the fats."

— Vayikra 9:24

It worked. Mamash (truly) a neis. The avodah that had been rehearsed in a structured, seven-day inauguration now landed in reality — and the Shechinah rested. Something that does not naturally belong inside teva entered it, and stayed.

V. The Fire That Went Too Far

And then, almost immediately, something shifts. Aharon's two older sons, Nadav and Avihu, bring their own ketores (incense offering):

> וַיַּקְרִיבוּ לִפְנֵי ה׳ אֵשׁ זָרָה אֲשֶׁר לֹא צִוָּה אֹתָם
>
> *"They brought before Hashem a foreign fire which He had not commanded them."*
>
> — Vayikra 10:1

That phrase is everything. Not simply that they brought something new — but that it was not commanded. It did not come through the structure that had just been established.

The mefarshim offer many explanations. They had drunk wine. They did not consult Moshe or Aharon. They acted on their own initiative. The seforim (sacred books) teach that a bit of mashke (drink), for those who can use it properly, can open a person up and elevate the neshama (soul). But here, it went wrong. Underneath all of it is something more fundamental: they wanted closeness. They saw that it was possible to bring the Shechinah into the world, and they wanted more of it. That desire was real. That desire was not wrong.

But not every movement toward closeness is avodah. Not every fire is meant to be brought.

We see the proof in the pesukim (verses) themselves. Their bodies and garments remained whole:

> וַיִּשָּׂאֵם בְּכֻתֹּנְתָּם אֶל מִחוּץ לַמַּחֲנֶה
>
> *"They carried them in their tunics outside the camp."*
>
> — Vayikra 10:5

The outer body remained whole. Something internal was taken. The mefarshim understand that on one level this was a punishment, and on another level there was tremendous closeness here. They came too near. They rose too high. The tragedy was not that they wanted too much.

The tragedy was that they reached without the structure that would allow that closeness to remain in this world.

VI. The Problem Was Not the Love

That is what makes this so relevant. The desire itself was not the problem. The love itself was not the problem. We could say they were acting m'toch chesed (from within lovingkindness) — from a place of expansion and longing, perhaps entirely so. But when that desire is not held within a structure, it becomes dangerous. When there is no gevul (boundary), a person can move beyond what they are meant to do, even when the intention is completely sincere.

This is where Sefiras HaOmer (the Counting of the Omer) becomes part of the story in a very real way. We are now in the second week of the Omer, the week of gevurah (strength and boundaries). The structure of the Omer is not random. Each week builds on the previous one. First comes chesed (lovingkindness) — expansion, openness, desire, movement outward. That is necessary. Without chesed, nothing begins. Without desire, nothing grows.

But immediately after chesed comes gevurah. Because if chesed is left on its own, it does not stay pure. It spills. It expands beyond what it can hold. It begins to lose form. Gevurah is what gives chesed a kli (vessel). It says: here is where this belongs, here is how this is expressed, here is how far this goes — and no further. Not to suppress the desire, but to shape it. Not to weaken the fire, but to allow it to last.

Without gevurah, chesed does not disappear — it overflows. And something that overflows without direction cannot be sustained. That is Nadav and Avihu. They had the chesed. They had the desire. They had the longing to come close. But without the gevurah, without the structure of *asher lo tzivah osam* (which He had not commanded them), that desire had no boundary. And when something holy has no boundary, it does not settle into the world. It burns.

VII. Gevurah Makes Closeness Possible

This is why we have halacha (Jewish law). This is why we have Shulchan Aruch (the Code of Jewish Law). Not to limit closeness, but to make closeness possible. HaKadosh Baruch Hu is telling us how to live with kedusha (holiness) in a way that does not consume us. Do this. Do not do this. Do this in this way, not in that way. Because the closer a person gets, the more necessary that structure becomes.

Many times in my life, people say to me: I live a spiritual life. I feel that this is right. My emotions tell me this is the correct path. And sometimes that is true. A Jew is not meant to be a robot. If there is no feeling, if there is no heart, if there is no longing, then something important is missing.

But if emotion is all we have, then we become deeply vulnerable to confusing what feels true with what is true. We start to treat our own inner movement as its own authority. We start to assume that sincerity is enough. It is not enough. A person can feel something powerfully and still be wrong about what to do with it. And if left unchecked, that tendency can grow into something much more serious — where a person no longer says, I feel close, but begins to say, I will serve Hashem on my own terms.

The framework is not what holds us back. It is what allows us to remain.

VIII. What Moshe Was Really Teaching

This brings us back to Moshe's seven days. Moshe was not only teaching the mechanics of the avodah. He was teaching the relationship between structure and intention. How to bring your whole self into the framework Hashem gave you, without breaking the framework in the name of bringing more of yourself.

Aharon received that. He hesitated — as the mefarshim tell us — and Moshe encouraged him. But then he stepped into the avodah that had been given to him, in the way it had been given to him, and the fire came down. Nadav and Avihu saw the same seven days. But in the end, they reached beyond what had been given.

That lesson shows us something deeper. It is not only about knowing what could be done, or even what feels right to do. It is about learning the gevurah of the mitzvot (commandments) — who should be doing the mitzvah (commandment), when it should be done, how it should be done, and whether it is a mitzvah at all, or something a person has created on their own: *asher lo tzivah osam* (which He had not commanded them).

This is what parents do. This is what teachers do. Not only giving information, but modeling form. Showing how a person lives with passion inside a framework. Showing how desire becomes avodah only when it is shaped. And this is what each of us has to ask: have I gone through the seven days? Have I let myself be taught? Or am I trying to live a life of Shmini without first becoming the kind of person who can carry it?

IX. From Shmini to Matan Torah

As we continue through Sefiras HaOmer and build toward Matan Torah (the Giving of the Torah), that question becomes sharper. Torah is the gift of structure. It is the form through which closeness becomes lasting. It is the vessel through which kedusha can actually be lived.

Every day of the Omer is another opportunity not only to want more, but to become fit for more. That is why this parsha belongs here. Right after Pesach, right after redemption, right after revelation, comes the reminder: if I try to live a life of Shmini without first having those seven days, then in my attempt to come closer to Hashem, I may get too close.

I may burn myself.

And that is not because closeness is wrong. It is because closeness is real.

The bracha (blessing) we say before Torah does not say Hashem gave us the Torah. It says:

> נֹתֵן לָנוּ אֶת הַתּוֹרָה
>
> *“Who gives us the Torah” — present tense, always giving.*
>
> — Birkas HaTorah (the Blessing over Torah)

Hashem is constantly giving us the Torah. We do not have to wait. We are always able to receive it — in the right and healthy way, within the structure that makes it possible to hold.

חַזַק וְאֶתְחַזַק

Good Shabbos